The Wet Pen

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 2, Episode 6

A shower reached the Mill route shelter before you did. The old visitor pen lay in a wet patch beside a blurred direction page. Nib tried one careful mark. It spread into an impressive puddle of ink. Later couriers would need a clearer direction than that.

“A very wet pen,” Nib reported gravely. “A dry one would be a splendid improvement,” Lark agreed.

Lark opened an earlier journal page on a flat, dry surface. Nib steadied its lower corner. One familiar word waited for another look.

“Try our earlier word before we start,” Lark invited gently. “You can sound it out or ask for help.”

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“Lowercase e makes the short middle sound in pen,” Lark explained clearly. “Listen to pen and pin. Keep p and n in place while the middle changes. The dry pen can write our message; the pin has a different job.”

“Join the parts and check the whole meaning,” Lark invited gently. “You can hear a part again whenever you want.”

On a little practice strip, you could try pen, pet, hen, net, red. Lark supplied unfamiliar story names herself. Nib waited while you looked right through each word.

“Read pen and pin on the kit pockets,” Lark invited gently. “Find what we need for a readable note.”

A short passage stayed in view. Lark paired each needed capital with its lowercase form and familiar sound before you began, leaving the sentence meanings for you to discover.

“Read the sentences in order,” Lark invited gently. “Let your finger follow if it helps. When you are ready, use the words to answer our question.”

Sam met Pat. Pat fed Sam.

“Who fed Sam?” Lark asked gently. “Look at the name that starts the second sentence.”

Lark kept the passage open so you could point to the part that helped. Nib listened before adding the picture.

Nib held a dry backing beneath a fresh page. Lark used the dry pen to draw the next turn beside a red route post. You could add red beneath the picture using familiar sounds and the new e. They hung the note beneath the roof, where the next shower would miss it. The two remaining invitations stayed dry in their pockets.

“Let's keep a written clue,” Lark suggested warmly. “Write red beside our picture. You can look at the example, follow it first, or try your own version. Then reread what you made.”

The wet pen stayed aside to dry. Your working pen returned to the kit. Beyond the shelter, a fallen log lay beside the Mill gate, and the gate would not swing. At least the route to it was clearly recorded now.